Copilot Studio: pay-as-you-go credits setup

Steps for the GitHub Copilot harness lesson, using example values. Replace them with your own.

Pay-as-you-go has no balance to top up. Creating the billing plan is the setup. Each Copilot Credit your agent uses (about $0.01 each) is billed afterwards to your Azure subscription. A billing plan only works if its region matches the region of your environment, so pick the region your environment is in. The example below uses West Europe.

Values used (examples only)

Azure subscription	Contoso Pay-As-You-Go
Resource group	rg-contoso-copilot-studio-weu
Resource group region	(Europe) West Europe
Billing plan name	ContosoCopilotStudioWEU
Meter	Copilot Studio only
Environment	Contoso Ltd. (default) - West Europe, Dataverse on
Budget	Monthly, £20, 80% email alert, scope Contoso Pay-As-You-Go

1. Create the resource group

A resource group is a free folder in Azure. Azure won't let anything exist loose, and when you save the billing plan Microsoft creates a small billing item that must be filed somewhere. This folder is where it goes.

1. Go to the Azure portal. Azure is Microsoft's cloud, and also the system that sends you the pay-as-you-go bill: https://portal.azure.com
2. Click **Resource groups**, then **Create**.
3. Subscription: **Contoso Pay-As-You-Go**. This is your billing account, with your payment method attached.
4. Name: **rg-contoso-copilot-studio-weu**.
5. Region: **(Europe) West Europe**. This must match where your environment lives.
6. Click **Review + create**, then **Create**.

2. Create the billing plan

A billing plan connects who pays (your Azure subscription), what is counted (the meter) and whose usage gets charged (the environment). Without one, an agent that uses credits has nobody to bill.

1. Go to the Power Platform admin center. Power Platform is the Microsoft product family Copilot Studio is built on, and this is its control panel for workspaces and billing: https://admin.powerplatform.microsoft.com
2. Open **Licensing > Billing plans > + New billing plan**.
3. Name: **ContosoCopilotStudioWEU**.
4. Azure subscription: **Contoso Pay-As-You-Go**.
5. Resource group: **rg-contoso-copilot-studio-weu**. If it isn't listed, cancel the panel and start **+ New billing plan** again, because the list won't refresh while the panel is open.
6. Meter: tick **Copilot Studio only**. A meter is a counter for one Microsoft product, and the plan bills only the meters you tick. Untick **Windows 365 for Agents** if it is ticked; that is for agents that operate a cloud PC.
7. Click **Next**. The region on the environments screen should match your resource group (West Europe in this example).
8. Tick **Contoso Ltd. (default)** and click **Update environments** (or **Save**). An environment is a separate workspace inside Power Platform where your agents live. Billing attaches to the environment, so any agent built there is covered.
9. Click **Refresh list** until the plan shows **Active** or **Enabled**.

3. Check the environment is attached

1. Click the **ContosoCopilotStudioWEU** row, then **See details**.
2. Under **Target environments**, confirm **Contoso Ltd. (default)** is listed.
3. If it is empty, click **Edit plan**, tick it and click **Update environments**.

4. Set up a spending alert

A budget doesn't stop spending. It emails you when spending reaches a limit you set. Pay-as-you-go has no cap, so this is your safety net.

1. In the Azure portal, open **Cost Management**, then **Monitoring > Budgets**.
2. Create or check a monthly budget of **£20** with scope **Contoso Pay-As-You-Go**.
3. Open it and confirm there is an alert at **80% (Actual)** and your email address is listed. Without these two, the budget does nothing.

5. Build in the right place and run the lesson

1. Open Copilot Studio, where you build and test agents: https://copilotstudio.microsoft.com
2. Check the environment selector at the bottom left reads **Contoso Ltd. (default)**. Don't use a Developer-type environment (often named after you) unless you have attached the billing plan to it.
3. On Home, click the **Agent** card tagged **GitHub Copilot**, which shows "Uses Copilot Credits". A Copilot Credit is the unit that measures agent activity, at about $0.01 each.
4. Credits are charged from the first build action, including creating, previewing, testing and evaluating.
5. After a test, check the agent's **Monitor** tab, which shows credits used by that agent. The capacity reports in the Power Platform admin center show use across the whole environment. Azure's Cost analysis can lag by hours up to about a day, so use the Power Platform view as your main check.

If the agent says it can't run for lack of capacity or billing, the plan probably isn't attached to that environment. Check step 3.

Prepaid alternative (not used in the lesson)

Closer to "pick a plan and pay for credits": a capacity pack is about $200 a month for 25,000 credits, and unused credits don't roll over. Buy it in the Microsoft 365 admin center (https://admin.microsoft.com) under **Billing > Purchase services**, then assign it under **Licensing > Capacity add-ons** in the Power Platform admin center. Menu names may differ.